

Lost Spring

Class 12 English (Flamingo) — Detailed Chapter Notes & Revision Guide

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Sub-title:	Stories of Stolen Childhood
Central Themes:	Grinding Poverty, Child Labour, Loss of Innocence, Vicious Cycle of Exploitation, Hope & Courage.

1. Chapter Overview

"**Lost Spring**" by Anees Jung analyzes the miserable conditions of underprivileged children who are denied childhood joys, education, and basic rights due to deep-rooted poverty and social exploitation. The title metaphorically compares childhood to "spring"—the season of joy, bloom, and growth—which is "lost" for millions of impoverished children in India. The chapter is divided into two parts:

- **Part I: "Sometimes I find a rupee in the garbage"** (Story of Saheb-e-Alam in Seemapuri)
- **Part II: "I want to drive a car"** (Story of Mukesh in Firozabad)

2. Part I: Saheb-e-Alam (Seemapuri, Delhi)

Key Details & Plot Points

- **Background:** Saheb and his family migrated from Dhaka, Bangladesh in 1971 after storms destroyed their homes and green fields.
- **Meaning of Name:** *Saheb-e-Alam* means "Lord of the Universe," creating a sharp irony given his destitute state as a barefoot ragpicker.
- **Seemapuri:** A settlement on the periphery of Delhi where over 10,000 ragpickers live in mud structures with roofs of tin and tarpaulin, lacking sewage, drainage, or running water.
- **Garbage as Gold:** For elders, garbage is a means of daily survival; for children, it is wrapped in wonder (they hope to find a ten-rupee note or a silver coin).
- **Identity:** They have no formal identity or passports, but hold voter cards that enable them to buy grain.
- **The Shift to a Tea Stall:** Saheb gets a job at a tea stall paying ₹800 plus meals. However, he loses his freedom and carefree look because the steel canister feels heavier than his plastic bag.

3. Part II: Mukesh (Firozabad, Uttar Pradesh)

Key Details & Plot Points

- **Firozabad:** The glass-blowing hub of India where almost every family is engaged in making glass bangles for women across the nation.
- **Working Conditions:** Over 20,000 children work illegally in dark, dingy cells near hot furnaces without air or light, often losing their eyesight before reaching adulthood.
- **Mukesh's Ambition:** Unlike his family, Mukesh dares to dream. He insists: "*I want to be a motor mechanic.*" He is willing to walk long distances to reach a garage.
- **Vicious Circle of Exploitation:** Bangle makers are trapped in a web formed by two forces:
 1. The stigma of the caste into which they are born.
 2. A vicious circle of *Sahukars* (moneylenders), middlemen, policemen, bureaucrats, and politicians.
- **Resignation vs. Hope:** The elder generation accepts poverty as their "*karam*" (destiny), but Mukesh's determination represents a ray of hope and daring.

4. Important Symbols & Quotes

- **Title ("Lost Spring"):** Spring symbolizes childhood, innocence, and happiness, which are stolen from these children by child labor and poverty.
- **The Steel Canister vs. Plastic Bag:** The plastic bag belonged to Saheb (symbolizing freedom), while the steel canister belongs to the tea stall owner (symbolizing servitude and loss of independence).
- **Glass Bangles:** Symbolize Indian women's *suhaag* (auspiciousness in marriage), yet they bring blindness and darkness to those who craft them.
- **"Garbage to them is gold":** Highlights the extreme poverty where basic survival depends on what others throw away.